

THE THREE W's

What else did my father enjoy? Three big W's: walking, worrying, and work. He loved them all. I never really saw him relax in the ways most folks do, I think because he loved to worry so much. Underneath his surface was a sort of endless undulating nervous energy that he liked to channel into worrying. He could worry about anything. It made him feel safe in some way. It was as if he somehow believed if he worried enough, he would have covered all the risks and nothing bad could happen to him. He would worry about the same things over and over and over. Because he always worried so much and because I was always a rebel, I never much worried. That bugged him. I have always been prone to simply thinking things through as thoroughly as I can once and then going with my decision. If I conclude I'm wrong, I may conclude to change. That drove him nuts. Father used to say to me, "Ken, I wish you would run scared more often. How about just once? I just wish you would run scared." He prided himself on "running scared." For the life of me, I couldn't think why I would want to live life that way; but he not only wanted that for me, he wanted it for himself.

In the garden, my father could sit and worry about all the things he cared about, and that made him feel better. It may well have contributed to why he made fewer investment mistakes than most investors do. He worried everything over until he had worried it to death. Maybe he had reduced risk that way. But that also may well have contributed to why he wasn't richer than he was. He wasn't willing to take risks on things for which he hadn't worried the mistakes down to marginality. In that way, he was never a big risk taker, and those who get really rich take bigger calculated risks than he was ever willing to take.

And walking? When Father was on a walk, his body was purging that excess undulating energy, and he was the most relaxed I ever saw him. He could take a long walk, in either the city or the woods, and calm down. He could talk while he was walking and be calm about it. He started every workday walking to and from the train station and ended his day that way, too. And if he wasn't walking fast, it didn't count. When Arthur and I used to take the train and walk into town with him and back, we would be sweaty